

# HAND Guidebook: Event-Ready Crafts & Gifts

**Introduction:** Arts and craft activities will play an important role as you volunteer with dementia patients. This section provides some general guidelines for how to approach or design these creative activities, as well as give some examples that you can implement at your sessions!

## Section 1: Design Principles for Dementia Patients

When making crafts for residents living with dementia, keep things simple, safe, and respectful. Dementia can affect vision, memory, language, and coordination. Because of this, small design choices matter. The goal is to create items that feel comforting and easy to use, not overwhelming.

- **Clarity:** Many residents you come across will have low vision or trouble processing certain complicated visuals. Try to use bold and high-contrast colors like dark text on a light background.
- **Comfort:** Soft materials like fleece, felt, or cotton can be very soothing for some patients. Items that feel nice to hold can help reduce restlessness. Choose textures that are gentle and comfortable, and avoid anything that could be scratchy or irritating. Simple sensory elements are often the most effective.
- **Safety:** Crafts should be sturdy and safe. Residents may drop items or handle them firmly. Avoid glass, fragile materials, or small pieces that could come loose. Make sure everything is securely attached and smooth to the touch.
- **Print:** Always print messages clearly in large block letters. Keep wording short and warm. Many seniors find cursive hard to read, and simple language makes your message more welcoming.

At the end of the day, your thoughtful design shows how much you care for these patients. When you prioritize clarity, comfort, and safety, your craft becomes something that respects the person receiving it and gives you the opportunity to engage with them more deeply.



1. **The Front:** Create light, cheerful designs such as flowers, sunshine, or birds. Avoid dark or “scary” imagery.
2. **The Message:** Write a warm, general greeting like:  
“Sending you the brightest wishes and hoping you have a wonderful day!”
3. **The Signature:** Sign as: “Your friends from the Duke HAND Club”

**Pro-Tip:** Do not mention holidays or specific dates so the cards can be used for any event year-round.

**Video Tutorial:** <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=6eXtoZBwjvA>

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## 2. Sensory “Sunshine” Goodie Bags

**Goal:** Small bags filled with items that stimulate the senses, including smell, touch, and sight.



**Video:** <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=xBusq3TDXxQ>

### Materials

- Small paper or fabric bags
- Ribbons
- Fillers (can be variety of objects)

### Tutorial Instructions:

Each bag should include a balance of sensory elements:

1. **Visual:** Include a bright, hand-decorated bookmark or a printed photo of a peaceful nature scene.
2. **Tactile:** Add a small “fidget” item such as a smooth painted rock or a soft felt flower.
3. **Olfactory:** Include a small lavender sachet or a lightly scented lotion. Ensure it is skin-friendly.

**Pro-Tip:** If including treats, stick to soft, familiar candies that are not a choking hazard.

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### 3. No-Sew Fleece Lap Blankets

**Reference Tutorial Video:** <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=R3UgR6rKEoE&t=557s>

**Goal:** To provide warmth and a sense of security during long events.



#### Materials

- Two 1.5-yard pieces of fleece, matching or contrasting colors
- Fabric scissors



**Tutorial Instructions:**

1. **Prep:** Layer the two pieces of fleece and cut a 4 x 4 inch square out of each corner.
2. **Fringing:** Cut 1-inch wide strips about 4 inches deep along all four sides.
3. **Tying:** Tie the top and bottom fringes together in a double knot.

**Pro-Tip:** Choose nostalgic patterns such as florals or classic plaids that might spark memories.

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## 4. Popsicle Stick Photo Frames

**Goal:** Create simple, sturdy photo frames that residents can use to display family photos or calming images.



**Video:** <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=awoHwaXtSIY>

**Materials:**

- Wide craft sticks (popsicle sticks)
- Strong craft glue or hot glue (adult supervision required)
- Foam shapes or large pom-poms
- Large buttons (securely attached)

- Printed photos (4x4 or 4x6)
- Cardstock backing
- Magnets or ribbon (optional for hanging)

### **Tutorial Instructions:**

#### **1. Build Frame:**

Glue 4 craft sticks into a square or rectangle. Reinforce the back with an extra stick. Let it dry.

#### **2. Add Photo Backing:**

Glue cardstock to the back on three sides, leaving the top open to slide in a photo (or glue photo securely in place).

#### **3. Decorate:**

Add large foam shapes or pom-poms to corners only. Keep colors bright and limit decorations.

#### **4. Display:**

Attach ribbon, a back stand, or a magnet if desired. Ensure all pieces are securely glued and edges are smooth.

**Pro-Tip:** Insert a peaceful nature image if family photos are not available. Landscapes with clear skies, gardens, or beaches work especially well.

**Video Tutorial:**  [Make a Picture Frame out of Popsicle Sticks!](#)